

Pause Before You Pay

Scam and fraud prevention guide

GUIDE

Scammers create urgency, fear, secrecy, or excitement to push people into acting before they verify. **Pause before you pay, click, share, or send a code.**

Warning signs

- **Urgency or pressure** to act right now, before you can think or check.
- **Secrecy:** "Don't tell your family or the bank."
- **Threats or fear:** arrest, lawsuit, account shutdown, or harm to a loved one.
- **Prizes, refunds, or overpayments** you did not expect.
- **Unexpected invoices** or renewal notices for things you did not buy.
- **Impersonation** of government, bank, utility, tech support, police, or family.

Red-flag payments and requests

- Payment by **gift card, cryptocurrency, wire transfer, payment app, or cash** (courier or mail).
- Asking for **passwords** or one-time **verification codes**.
- Asking for your **Social Security number**, bank, or card details.
- Asking you to install an app or allow **remote access** to your device.
- Asking you to move money to a "safe" account.

⚠ PAUSE BEFORE YOU PAY

- 1 **Verify independently.** Hang up and call using the official website, statement, or card, not the number they gave you.
- 2 **Never share passwords or one-time codes.** Real organizations will not ask for them.
- 3 **Ask a trusted person** before paying, sending money, or installing software.
- 4 **Search the name or number** online with the word "scam."

If you may have been scammed

- 1 **Stop contact and preserve evidence:** screenshots, messages, receipts, numbers, dates.
- 2 **Call your bank, card issuer, or payment platform immediately** using official contact details.
- 3 **Change passwords** and turn on multi-factor authentication (MFA).
- 4 **Report** to the platform used, and to the FTC at [ReportFraud.ftc.gov](https://www.ftc.gov/identitytheft).
- 5 For identity theft recovery steps, visit [IdentityTheft.gov](https://www.identitytheft.gov).
- 6 File a report with local law enforcement if money or identity was stolen.

! **Call 911** if you are in immediate danger or a crime is in progress (for example, someone is coming to your home to collect money).

MY BANK / CARD OFFICIAL PHONE

TRUSTED PERSON TO CALL FIRST

LOCAL NON-EMERGENCY NUMBER

Suspicious contact notes Write it down: it helps your bank, the platform, and investigators

Date / time	Who contacted you / platform	What was requested	Action taken